

Now, Pat doesn't put anything inside Slackware unless and until he's completely satisfied with the piece of code. He'll still make you use LiLo instead of Grub, by default! So, all this praise coming from him could only mean how impressive KDE4 is and what lies ahead in the coming years.

Installation and configuration

I think the first Slackware version I had tried was 9.1—that was in 2003. As far as I can remember, things pretty much look the same, even today. It's the same old ncurses-based wizard that's fool-proof and stable.

Anyway, for the uninitiated, I'll try to walk you through the Slackware path. After booting the CD, you're prompted on whether you wish to use a US English keymap (for your keyboard) or not. We Indians do, so simply hit **Enter**. This brings you to the login screen.

Log in as the root, and type **setup** to start the installation. Note that if you need to configure your partitions, the installer won't offer you anything. So, do your partitioning tid-bits using the **cfdisk** utility and then proceed with **setup**.

This will bring you to an ncurses-based menu. Read what the **Help** option offers if you like, or jump straight to the **addswap** option. Follow the instructions from there on, and you should be up and running.

A few things I noticed:

- Now that the kernel version is upped to 2.6.29, Slackware offers ext4 as the default filesystem. Of course, other choices like ext3, XFS, JFS, etc, are still available.
- It's better if you choose the recommended package installation sections. Although this will install everything available in the DVD, it won't bug you with all those prompts.
- The package installation on my C2D 1.6GHz HP 550 laptop with 1GB of RAM took only 15 minutes. Considering that the total install size is more than 4 GB, that's pretty fast.

General configuration and desktop

Slackware still boots you to init level 3—that is the command line interface with networking enabled. You need to start X with either **startx** or by launching the display manager—for example, **kdm**. This setting is nice if I were to run a server on it, but I'd rather have the desktop show up by default. So, it's time to open **/etc/inittab** and set the default runlevel to 4—yes, it's not 5, like other distros.

You'll also need to set up a normal user account, manually. Unfortunately, that was not a part of the installer's job. Anyway, run the following command to create one:

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